

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN JAMAICA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the land, water, and coast of Jamaica, and one campaign showed the country that even a megaproject backed by a foreign government and pushed by the state can be stopped. In 2013, the government announced that a Chinese company would build a vast transshipment port and logistics hub — a project of around one and a half billion US dollars — on the **Goat Islands**, two islands inside the **Portland Bight Protected Area**, Jamaica's largest protected area and its greatest mangrove system, home to endemic birds, the fish that feed coastal communities, and the last refuge of the critically endangered Jamaican iguana nearby. The deal had been made largely in secret; environmental stakeholders learned of it from the newspapers. But a coalition rose to fight it — the **Jamaica Environment Trust** and the "Save Goat Islands" campaign, scientists, birders, fishers, and ordinary Jamaicans — attacking the secrecy, documenting the harm, and refusing to let the country's largest protected area be bulldozed for a port. By 2016, the government announced that the Goat Islands were no longer being considered. The protected area was saved. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a campaign works. The Portland Bight Protected Area, established in 1999, spans some 1,876 square kilometres of coast, cays, and wetland — the island's largest protected area and its greatest mangrove system, holding dozens of endemic plants and birds found nowhere else. The port, to be built by a Chinese state engineering company at a cost of around one and a half billion US dollars, would have bulldozed the Goat Islands, dredged the seabed, and filled the wetlands. The campaign that stopped it did not rely on a single tactic: it exposed the secrecy of the deal, marshalled the science on what would be lost, rallied the fishers whose grounds were at stake, and drew in international conservationists — until, three years on, the government quietly let the plan go.

The Jamaica story teaches two things about defending land and coast here — including its honest limits, which this guide states from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the legal challenge, and the country's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Jamaican, and it drew on the tools of an open democracy. **A determined coalition, led by strong environmental organisations and rooted in communities, can use protected-area law, the courts, the demand for transparency, and public opinion to stop or contest a destructive project — even one the state and a foreign power want built.** That power — the environmental movement and its legal advocacy, the protected-area law, the Maroon and community claims to the land, the fight against secrecy, and the public's voice — is Jamaica's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Goat Islands campaign work as a model, and what a later campaign can copy, was the way it combined an expert core with a broad base. At its centre stood Jamaica's established environmental organisations, which knew the law, the agencies, and how to press a case; around them gathered the scientists who could say precisely what would be destroyed, the fishers and coastal communities who lived off the threatened waters, and an international network of conservationists who cared about an endangered endemic species and a great protected area. That combination — legal and scientific expertise bound to a real, rooted, and wide public constituency — is the Jamaican template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The Goat Islands win was real, but the government **moved the port plan elsewhere** rather than abandoning such ambitions entirely, so vigilance remained. And Jamaica's other great fight — over the **Cockpit Country**, the rugged, Maroon, water-giving heart of the island threatened by **bauxite mining** — has been only a **partial, contested victory**: a protected boundary was won, but drawn smaller than campaigners sought, excluding key sites and the full aquifer, leaving mining to press at the edges, because the state treats bauxite as central to the economy. The Cockpit Country deserves its own honest reckoning, because it shows both the reach and the limits of these tools. After years of campaigning, the government in 2017 finally designated a Cockpit Country Protected Area within which bauxite mining would be barred — a real gain. But the boundary it drew was markedly smaller than the one the campaigners and the science had called for, it left out important cultural and historical sites and much of the aquifer that supplies the region's water, and it set no buffer, so that mining could press right up to the line. A protected core was won; a fully protected Cockpit Country was not, and the fight over the edges continues. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a Jamaican coalition that wields protected-area law, the courts, and public opinion — and the economic pressures, the partial wins, and the persistence of the threat that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a project and assume "the government and

the investors have decided and nothing can be done," and never organise, never document, never challenge the permit or the process, never build the coalition or reach the public. They generate private loss without a public claim. The gap between a community that saves its coast and one that loses it is rarely courage — Jamaicans have shown it in abundance. It is method: knowing how to organise the coalition, document the harm, wield the protected-area law and the courts, demand transparency, and move the public.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Jamaican system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a port, a mine, a hotel, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the process, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build proof of the harm and the flaws)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (organise the coalition and the communities)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (protected-area law, the permit, and the courts)
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STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it national)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the coalition sustains the pressure; a court filing or a transparency demand is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, a permit quashed, a protected area held. The Goat Islands campaign did exactly this — it exposed the secrecy, documented the harm, built a broad coalition, threatened the legal ground, and carried the fight to the nation.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Jamaica's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The environmental movement and its legal advocacy.** Jamaica has **strong environmental organisations** — the Jamaica Environment Trust foremost — that document, campaign, and litigate, a durable and expert force.
- **Protected-area law.** Jamaica's **protected areas and environmental law** give communities a real legal shield, as the Portland Bight Protected Area status did for Goat Islands. The value of a protected designation is that it changes the legal terrain of a fight: a project proposed inside a protected area does not begin from a neutral position but must overcome a status the law has already granted the land, and that status gives a community a concrete, documented ground to stand on rather than a mere preference to be weighed against development. Establishing early and precisely whether your project touches a protected area, a forest reserve, or a designated watershed — and exactly what that designation forbids — is therefore among the most valuable things a Jamaican campaign can do.
- **The demand for transparency.** Secrecy is a project's weakness; the **demand for openness** — for the assessments, the deals — is a powerful lever in a democracy that values it. Secrecy cuts against a project in two ways at once, and a campaign should exploit both. Legally, a deal or a permit advanced without the disclosure and consultation the process requires is vulnerable to challenge on exactly that ground. Politically, the very fact of secrecy — a major project affecting public land settled behind closed doors, revealed to the public and even to the officials charged with the protected area only through the press — is itself a scandal that turns opinion, because it offends a democratic public's sense that such decisions belong to it. The Goat Islands campaign made the secrecy of the deal one of its sharpest weapons, and a later campaign should do the same.
- **Maroon and community land claims.** The **Maroons' historic autonomy** and communities' ties to the land, as in the Cockpit Country, are a distinctive claim.
- **Public opinion and the free press.** In an open democracy, a **mobilised public and a free press** move the government, as they moved it on Goat Islands.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always fully win. Goat Islands was saved, but the **port ambition moved on**. Cockpit Country is a **partial, contested victory** against the pull of the bauxite economy. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Jamaica offers — the movement, the protected-area law, the courts, transparency, and the public — as Jamaicans used them to save a protected area and to win, and keep fighting for, the Cockpit Country.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the leverage — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Jamaican development or extraction project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the agencies. The **government, the Cabinet, and the agencies** — the environmental regulator (NEPA/NRCA), the relevant ministries, the Port Authority — approve projects, grant permits, and negotiate the deals, sometimes in secret, as the Goat Islands deal was made. Knowing which body holds which piece of the decision is a practical necessity, because a Jamaican project may run through several hands at once — the environmental regulator that grants the permit, the ministry that champions the investment, an authority that manages the asset, and the Cabinet that strikes the deal — and a campaign that presses the wrong one wastes its effort. Map early which agency issued each approval your project depends on, and which one holds the power to withdraw it, because that tells you where to direct the documents, the objections, and the public pressure.

The investors. Foreign and domestic investors — a Chinese port builder, a bauxite company, a hotel developer — propose and build the projects.

The protected-area and environmental law. Jamaica's **protected areas, environmental permits, and the law behind them** are a real constraint and a lever, as the Portland Bight status was.

The courts. Jamaica's **courts** can review permits and decisions and hold the agencies to the law — a real, if slower, lever, as environmental litigation has shown.

The movement and the public. The **environmental organisations, the communities, the Maroons, and the public** are the force that documents, campaigns, litigates, and mobilises — the coalition that won at Goat Islands.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government or investor proposal, through **environmental permitting and assessment** by the regulator, sometimes shrouded in **secrecy**, toward construction — with the **movement, the communities, the courts, and the public** able to expose, document, litigate, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Jamaican doors are the **protected-area law, the environmental permit and the courts, the demand for transparency, and the public campaign.** Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **whether it touches a protected area, whether the process was open and lawful, and whether the public can be moved**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Process, and the Protected Land

Behind a project stand a proponent — an investor, the government, or both — and the agencies that approve it. Trace who profits, who decided, and — importantly in Jamaica — **whether the project touches a protected area or a vital watershed, whether the process and the permit were open and lawful, whether the affected communities and Maroons were heard, and what the project does to the land, the water, the reef, and the endemic life.** Two questions unlock most Jamaican fights: **Does it threaten protected land or water, and was the process lawful and open?** and **Can the coalition and the public be mobilised to move the government?** The protected land and the public are, together, the heart of most Jamaican campaigns. The two reinforce one another in a way particular to a democracy that prizes its natural heritage: the protected status gives a campaign its legal foothold and its moral authority, while the public's attachment to that heritage — to a great protected area, an endemic creature, a river that gives the region its water — gives it the political force that moves a government. A campaign that leans only on the law may win a technical point without the public behind it; one that leans only on sentiment may stir feeling without a legal ground to act on; the Goat Islands campaign, like the strongest Jamaican fights, pressed both together.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, which can review a permit; the **protected-area and environmental law**; the **environmental organisations** and their legal advocacy; the **free press**; the **Maroons and the affected communities**; and the **public**, whose voice moved the government on Goat Islands. In Jamaica, the **environmental movement's advocacy, the protected-area law, and**

public opinion are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project that threatens a protected area, that rests on a secret or flawed process, and that faces a broad, expert coalition rarely proceeds untouched — as the Goat Islands port did not. You do not have to choose one front: the same documented case — the protected status, the secrecy, the harm to the endemic life — can go to the courts, the agencies, the press, and the public at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others. A Jamaican campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together — the protected-area law and the courts, the exposure of the secret deal, and the roused public — so that a government facing a legal challenge, a scandal, and a mobilised nation at the same time finds a project it can no longer defend, as it found the Goat Islands port.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Jamaican and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **threatens a protected area or watershed**, whether the **process was secret or flawed**, whether the **coalition and the environmental organisations** engage, whether the **courts** can be reached, and whether **public opinion** can be moved. Where the project threatens protected land and the process was flawed or secret, Jamaica's levers are real, as Goat Islands showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the bauxite economy pulls hard the other way, and that some wins, like Cockpit Country, are partial and contested.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Protected-area / environmental law	35-60%	months-years	low-moderate	A legal shield; a project halted or contested
Transparency demand	30-55%	ongoing	low	Secrecy broken; the deal exposed
Court / permit challenge	30-55%	1-4 years	low-moderate	A permit quashed; the agency held to law
Coalition & the environmental movement	40-65%	ongoing	low-moderate	A broad, expert, durable front
Public opinion & the press	40-65%	ongoing	low	The government moved
Community & Maroon claims	30-55%	varies	low	The land and water defended; rights asserted
Media & national attention	40-65%	ongoing	low	The nation engaged
All steps (protected land, flawed/secret process)	45-70%	months-years	low-moderate	Stopped, quashed, or protected
All steps (strong economic pull, sound process)	25-50%	months-years	low-moderate	Partial protection; delay; the record

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Jamaica's real strengths are distinctive — **protected-area law**, the **environmental movement's advocacy**, the **demand for transparency**, the **courts**, and **public opinion**. Its constraints are specific: the **bauxite economy** pulls hard toward mining; some wins are **partial and contested**, as Cockpit Country's boundary was; and a stopped project may **move rather than vanish**, as the port ambition did.

A note on cost: organising the coalition, documenting the harm, demanding transparency, and mobilising the public cost mainly time and commitment, and Jamaica's strong environmental organisations make legal and technical expertise genuinely available. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the coalition's breadth and the persistence to expose the secrecy and move the public — exactly what the Goat Islands campaign required.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (project stopped, quashed, or protected)

PROTECTED LAND + FLAWED OR SECRET PROCESS + A BROAD COALITION:

All steps combined:	45-70%
Coalition + movement:	40-65%
Public opinion + press:	40-65%
Protected-area law + courts:	35-60%
Single step:	5-65%

STRONG ECONOMIC PULL / SOUND PROCESS -- bauxite or state priority, no flaw:

All steps combined:	25-50%
Partial protection:	a contested boundary, a limited win
Delay / the record:	more achievable than a full stop
Single step:	5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Jamaica are **the coalition and the environmental movement, protected-area law, and public opinion**, amplified by the courts and the demand for transparency. Goat Islands shows the ceiling: a coalition exposed a secret deal, mobilised the nation, and saved a protected area. But the honest floor is real too: the bauxite economy pulls hard, Cockpit Country's win was partial and contested, and a stopped port merely moved. Most Jamaican fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the movement, the protected-area law, the courts, and public opinion are powerful levers — decisive when protected land is threatened and the process is flawed, weaker against a strong economic pull and a sound process, where the realistic win is partial protection, delay, and a record. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a campaign defending clearly protected land against a project advanced in secret is in the strong band and can aim to stop it outright, as the Goat Islands coalition did; a campaign facing a project the state deems economically vital, advanced through a sound process, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at partial protection, delay, and a record, as the Cockpit Country fight has had to. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The coalition and the environmental movement** — Jamaica's foundation; the broad, expert alliance of organisations, scientists, communities, and the public that saved Goat Islands.
2. **Protected-area law and public opinion** — the legal shield of protected status and the mobilised public that together move the government.
3. **The demand for transparency and the courts** — exposing the secret deal and challenging the flawed permit, the levers that break a project open.
4. **Community and Maroon claims** — the ties to the land and water, and the Maroons' historic autonomy, that ground the defence, as in the Cockpit Country.
5. **Media and national attention** — the coverage that engages the nation and raises the cost of proceeding.

What Jamaican Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **A coalition can move the state** — Goat Islands united organisations, scientists, and the public and won. **Protected status is a shield** — the Portland Bight designation was central. **Secrecy is a weakness** — exposing the secret deal turned opinion. **The bauxite economy pulls hard** — Cockpit Country's win was only partial. **A stopped project can move** — the port ambition relocated. The through-line: **build the coalition; document the harm; wield the protected-area law and the courts; demand transparency; and move the public — because in Jamaica a broad, expert movement can stop even a project the state and a foreign power want built.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds, which in Jamaica is often the protected status, the flawed or secret process, and the movable public. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the port planned in secret for our largest protected area, threatening the mangroves and the iguana" is a campaign — the campaign that saved Goat Islands. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Does it threaten protected land or a vital watershed? This is the first Jamaican question. Does the project touch a **protected area, a forest reserve, a key watershed, or endemic habitat** — because protected status and vital water are a project's strongest obstacle and the community's strongest shield, as the Portland Bight status was for Goat Islands. This is the first thing a campaign should establish, because it so often determines the strength of the whole fight. Land that already carries a protective designation — a protected area, a forest reserve, a designated watershed — gives a

community a legal and moral starting point that unprotected land does not, and even land that is not formally protected but holds a great endemic value or supplies a region's water can often be defended on those grounds. Determining early exactly what status the threatened land holds, and what that status forbids, tells a campaign at once how firm a footing it stands on.

2. Was the process open and lawful? Was the project's **deal, permit, and assessment** made **openly and lawfully**, or in **secrecy** and haste — because secrecy and a flawed process are a project's central weaknesses, as they were at Goat Islands.

3. What does it do to the land, water, reef, and endemic life? What **harm** does the project cause — to the land, the water and watershed, the reef and mangroves, the endemic species, the community's livelihood — and what does the community stand to lose? Give particular weight to endemic species and to water, because both carry a force in Jamaica that few arguments match. An island as rich as Jamaica in creatures found nowhere else on earth — its iguana, its birds, its plants — offers a campaign a cause that resonates at home and abroad, because the loss of such a species is final and irreplaceable; and a project that threatens the water a region drinks, as bauxite mining threatens the Cockpit Country's aquifer, strikes at daily life in a way that unites a community. Documenting the threat to the endemic life and the water, precisely and vividly, connects a local fight to values the whole nation holds.

4. Can the coalition and the public be built? Can the **environmental organisations, the communities, the Maroons, the scientists, and the public** be united into a broad coalition, as they were for Goat Islands? The coalition is worth assembling with real deliberation rather than left to form on its own, because its completeness is what has repeatedly proved decisive: a campaign should ask, at the outset, who can speak for the affected livelihoods, who can supply the scientific authority, who holds the relevant land rights, who can carry the legal fight, and who can reach the national and international public — and then set about recruiting each of those voices. A fight that gathers all of them, as the Goat Islands campaign did, presents the state with a breadth it cannot easily divide or dismiss; one that rests on a single group is far more easily set aside.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which agency and investor are behind it, who profits; and which courts, environmental laws, organisations, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a large project is proposed, in secret, for a protected area, threatening the mangroves and the endemic wildlife and the fishers who depend on the sea.

Working the five questions: does it threaten **protected land**? Was the process **open and lawful**? What **harm** to the reef, the mangroves, the endemic life? Can the **coalition and public** be built? And the deciders are the agency and the investor, with the courts, the movement, the press, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will build it" to a target list: expose the secrecy; document the harm to the protected area; build the coalition; challenge the process and the permit; and move the public. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how the Goat Islands were saved. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a vague alarm about a project into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — establish the protected status, expose the secrecy, document the harm, build the coalition, move the public — each tied to a specific lever that Jamaica's open democracy actually provides. That reframing, from resignation to a plan built on the country's real strengths, is the difference the five questions make, and the first of them, whether protected land or vital water is threatened, often decides how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, an agency, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Jamaica, the protected status, the secrecy, and the harm are precisely what a campaign turns into pressure, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Deal, the Permit, and the Process

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **deal, the permits, the environmental assessment, and the protected-area status** — and where these are hidden, make the **secrecy itself the issue**, as the Goat Islands

campaign made the government's secrecy a central charge. Establish **whether the process was lawful** — whether the assessment was done, the public consulted, the protected-area law respected. Document the **protected status** of the land and water, because it is the community's strongest legal shield. The gap between what the law and openness require and what was done is where many Jamaican cases are grounded. The environmental assessment deserves particularly close and, where possible, expert scrutiny, because it is both legally required and technically involved, and it is in its detail that a project's vulnerabilities hide — a harm to the mangroves understated, an effect on an endemic species ignored, an alternative site never seriously considered, a consultation skipped. Where a project has been rushed, as large investment projects often are, the assessment is frequently the weakest link, and a community that reads it carefully rather than assuming it sound often finds the very flaw on which a legal challenge, or a public case, can be built.

Layer 2: The Harm to the Land, Water, and Endemic Life

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **protected land, the water, the reef, and the endemic life** at the centre. Record the **harm** — to the mangroves and the reef, the watershed and the aquifer, the endemic species, the fishers' catch, the community — that the project would cause, as the Goat Islands campaign documented the threat to the mangroves, the iguana, and the fishers. Document what the community **stands to lose**. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** and gather **expert and scientific evidence**, which Jamaica's strong scientific community supplies. This is the case that moves the courts, the nation, and the world.

Layer 3: The Protected Status, the Flaw, and the Harm

Finally, document the case. Does the project **threaten protected land or a vital watershed**? Was the **process secret or unlawful**? Is the **harm** to the reef, the mangroves, the endemic life, and the community real and grave? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, the campaign, and the public — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Jamaican fights, because here a project sold as beneficial is revealed to threaten a protected area, to rest on a secret or flawed process, and to endanger the endemic life and the community — exactly the case that saved the Goat Islands. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the protected status, the secrecy or flaw, and the harm — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the protected status and the flawed process are what a court can act on, the harm to the endemic life and the fishers is what moves the public and the scientists, and the secrecy is what turns a policy dispute into a scandal. A campaign that documents only the harm may move hearts without a legal footing; one that documents only the legal flaw may win a point without the public behind it; the campaigns that prevail in Jamaica, as the Goat Islands campaign did, build all three and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Jamaican cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the protected status, the flawed or secret process, and the harm.

The Deal, the Permit, and the Paper Trail

- **The deal and the agreement** — the terms of the project, often the very thing kept secret.
- **The permits and the environmental assessment** — whether done, and whether sound, the central documents.
- **The protected-area status and boundaries** — the legal shield, and whether the project intrudes on it.
- **The consultation record** — whether the communities and Maroons were heard.
- **The investor and the beneficiaries** — who profits, and where the project sits in policy.

How to Get Them

The permits, assessments, and protected-area status are matters of record, obtainable from the environmental regulator and through access-to-information requests; the deal itself may require the transparency fight, making the **secrecy the story** where it persists. Lean on **allies**: Jamaica's **environmental organisations** — the Jamaica Environment Trust foremost — which know the law, the agencies, and how to litigate; the scientists and the universities; the Maroon and community authorities; and the international conservation networks that supported Goat Islands. Move promptly: obtaining the assessment and the protected status early lets you challenge a project before it hardens, and lets you move the public while the decision is still open, as the Goat Islands coalition moved it. Timing matters here and repays acting on early: the protected status, the assessment, and the terms of the deal are most useful obtained and publicised while the decision is still open and construction has not begun, because a project is far easier to stop before money is committed

and ground is broken, and public opinion is far easier to shape before the project acquires the look of a settled thing. The Goat Islands campaign moved quickly to expose the deal and rally the public while the plan was still being weighed; a community that acts with the same speed, securing the documents and rousing the coalition while the ground is still whole, gives itself by far the best chance.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — to the mangroves, the reef, the watershed, the endemic species, dated and documented.
- **The protected status** — the designation, the boundaries, the law that protects the land and water.
- **The secrecy or the flaw** — the hidden deal, the missing assessment, the unlawful step.
- **The community and Maroon claim** — the ties to the land and water, and the historic rights.
- **Testimony and science** — from fishers, communities, Maroons, and the scientists who know the endemic life.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the deal, the permit, the protected status, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a fisher, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, a judge, and a member of the public all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the investor or the agency pushes back. In a country where protected status and public opinion decide, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest proof of the protected status, the secrecy, and the harm — is very often the one that wins, as the Goat Islands coalition won.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE COALITION AND THE COMMUNITIES

Evidence and law do not win on their own. An organised coalition does — and in Jamaica, the Goat Islands campaign proved that a broad alliance of environmental organisations, scientists, communities, and the public can move even a government committed to a foreign-backed megaproject. A campaign's strength here is that coalition: broad, expert, and rooted in the affected communities.

Phase 1: The Core and the Community

Start with a committed core rooted in the **affected communities** — the fishers, the farmers, the Maroons, the people whose land, water, and livelihood are at stake — and the **environmental organisations** whose expertise anchors the fight. Assign roles — documentation, legal, media, community organising, and coalition liaison. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the permit quashed, the protected area held — and on what the community will and will not accept. Draw on Jamaica's strong environmental infrastructure, the organisations and scientists who carried Goat Islands.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **affected communities and the fishers**; the **environmental organisations** — the Jamaica Environment Trust and its peers — which bring the legal and campaigning expertise; the **scientists and the universities**, whose evidence on the endemic life and the watershed is decisive; the **Maroons and their authorities**, where their land and rights are engaged; the **international conservation networks**, which amplified Goat Islands; and the **wider public and the free press**, whose voice moves the government. The Goat Islands campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — organisations, scientists, fishers, birders, and a public roused against a secret deal — which is precisely the spread a winning Jamaican campaign needs. The breadth of the Goat Islands coalition was not incidental but decisive, because each part answered an objection the others could not. When the government argued jobs and investment, the fishers could speak for the livelihoods the project would destroy; when it minimised the environmental cost, the scientists could name the endemic species and the mangrove system that would be lost; when it treated the matter as a domestic affair, the international conservation networks made it a question of global heritage; and through it all the environmental organisations supplied the legal pressure and the sustained campaign. A community should build that same breadth deliberately, recruiting the voices that can meet each argument the state and the investor will make.

A worked coalition example. Facing a project in a protected area, the fishers and communities form the base; the environmental organisations bring the law and the campaign; the scientists supply the evidence on the endemic life; the

international networks amplify; and the press and public move the government. No single group could carry it; together they cover the ground, the science, the law, and the public — the model that saved Goat Islands. What is worth drawing from that model is how each element supplied what the others lacked: the fishers and communities brought the moral standing of those whose living was at stake, the scientists the authority to say exactly what would be lost, the environmental organisations the legal and campaigning machinery, and the international networks the global spotlight. A community beginning a fight should honestly assess which of these it already holds and which it must recruit, because it is the completeness of the coalition, not the intensity of any single part, that has repeatedly proved decisive in Jamaica's environmental battles.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Jamaican fight can run through a long campaign or a longer legal and boundary battle, as Cockpit Country has for years. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the deal exposed, an assessment obtained, a court filing, a wave of coverage, an international ally won. Keep the coalition broad and the communities engaged, and guard against the **division and the wearing-down** — the promise of jobs to some, the economic argument that splits a community, the long grind against the bauxite pressure — that will be used to break the fight, as the Cockpit Country fight has had to endure. Expect these pressures, because they are the standard response to a campaign that cannot be quickly dismissed: the promise of jobs or development to divide a community, the argument that the nation's prosperity depends on the very project in dispute, and the sheer attrition of a fight that may run for years against a well-resourced interest. The defences are breadth and endurance — a coalition wide enough that no single inducement can split it, a case grounded in facts that do not fade, and an organisation built to last — the same qualities that have kept the Cockpit Country defenders in the field across nearly two decades of pressure.

Phase 4: Moving the Public and Exposing the Secrecy

Here is Jamaica's distinctive strength. In an open democracy, **public opinion moves the government** — and the fastest way to move it is to **expose the secrecy** and the harm. Make the **hidden deal the scandal**, as the Goat Islands campaign made the government's secrecy a central charge; take the threat to the protected area, the endemic life, and the fishers to the **press and the public**; and rally the coalition, the scientists, and the international networks behind a clear, documented case. Keep the campaign **disciplined, factual, and broad**, because a wide, credible, well-evidenced movement is what moves a government, and the investor and the state will seize on any exaggeration. Credibility is a particular asset in a Jamaican campaign, because the environmental organisations at its core have built their standing over many fights and cannot afford to squander it, and because a well-informed public and press will notice an overstatement and use it to discount the whole case. A campaign should therefore hold itself to a strict accuracy, letting the documented facts — the protected status, the secrecy, the harm to the endemic life — carry the argument, because in a country where these fights are won in the arena of public opinion, a reputation for telling the exact truth is worth more than any rhetorical flourish. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the investor, and the nation — that the public will not accept the destruction of a protected area done in secret, as the public would not accept it at Goat Islands.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — PROTECTED-AREA LAW, THE PERMIT, AND THE COURTS

Jamaica's protected-area and environmental law, and its courts, are a real lever — environmental litigation has held agencies to the law before, and the threat of it shapes what a government dares. You do not need a courtroom victory to win: a permit quashed, a protected status upheld, an agency forced to follow its own law, or a project abandoned under legal and public pressure can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and the environmental organisations early — but understand the tools.

Protected-Area and Environmental Law

The first and most distinctive lever is **protected-area and environmental law**. A project that intrudes on a **protected area, a forest reserve, or a key watershed** faces a real legal obstacle, and the law governing **environmental permits and assessments** requires proper process. Establish the protected status and the legal requirements, and hold the project to them; the Portland Bight Protected Area status was central to the case against the Goat Islands port, and protected status is the community's strongest legal shield. A campaign should therefore treat the protected designation not as a background fact but as a live legal instrument to be studied and wielded: learn exactly what the designating law and any management plan forbid, what obligations they place on the agencies, and what standard of assessment and

consultation a project within the area must meet, because these are the specific hooks on which a challenge hangs. It was the protected status of the Portland Bight area, and the requirements that came with it, that gave the case against the Goat Islands port its legal spine, and a later campaign should mine its own protected designation for the same. Where the protected status has been weakened or drawn too narrowly, as in the Cockpit Country, the fight shifts to defending and enlarging it — contesting a boundary drawn to suit a mining interest, pressing for the buffer and the aquifer the science requires, and insisting that a designation mean what it says. That, too, is a legal and political struggle worth waging, because a protected status is only as strong as the community's willingness to defend its lines.

The Permit and the Courts

The second lever is the **permit and the courts**. Jamaica's **courts** can review whether an environmental permit was lawfully granted and whether the regulator followed the law and its own process, and environmental litigation has established that the agencies can be **held to account**. Scrutinise the permit and the assessment for flaws, and challenge them — a project that skipped the assessment, or whose permit was unlawfully granted, is vulnerable, and even the threat of litigation can stall a project and force disclosure. This is a point a campaign should use deliberately, because the value of the legal lever is not only in a final courtroom victory, which may be years away, but in the pressure the credible prospect of it applies at every stage. A well-founded threat to challenge an unlawful permit can make an agency pause, reconsider, or disclose what it would rather keep hidden; it can make an investor weigh the delay and the risk; and it signals to the government that the project will not pass quietly. A community that has done the legal groundwork, and can show it is ready and able to litigate, wields that readiness as a lever in itself, quite apart from whether a case is ever finally decided.

Transparency and the Law

The third lever, distinctive to fights like Jamaica's, is **transparency**. Where a deal is made in secret, the **demand for disclosure** — through access-to-information law and public and legal pressure — is itself a lever, because secrecy is both a vulnerability and a scandal, and forcing a project into the open exposes its flaws and turns the public against it, as it did at Goat Islands.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Protected-area and permit challenges go through the **environmental regulator and the courts**; transparency through **access-to-information law and public pressure**; and the whole legal effort through **the environmental organisations** that know the routes. Get help early: Jamaica's environmental organisations and public-interest lawyers — the Jamaica Environment Trust foremost — know the law, the agencies, and the courts, and their expertise was central to Jamaica's environmental wins. Reaching these organisations early rather than late can shape the whole course of a fight, because the earliest decisions — which approval to challenge, on what ground, within what deadline, and how to frame the public case — often determine whether a campaign can succeed at all, and the environmental organisations have fought these exact battles before and carry the accumulated knowledge of what works against a given agency or a given kind of project. A community that brings them in at the first sign of a threat, rather than after a permit has issued, gives itself the benefit of that experience when it matters most. Help engaged early — before a project hardens — is worth far more than help sought after, and in Jamaica the strongest strategy marries the **protected-area law and the courts** to the **coalition, the transparency demand, and public opinion**.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an agency, a journalist, a scientist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a port was planned in secret for a protected area, threatening the largest mangrove system and the habitat of an endemic, critically endangered species, without a proper public assessment. That one fact becomes:

- **A legal argument:** the project intrudes on a protected area and the process broke the law — the case before the courts, as at Goat Islands.
- **A transparency argument:** the deal was made in secret, hidden from the public and even the protected-area

managers — the scandal that turns opinion.

- **A scientific argument:** the project would destroy irreplaceable endemic habitat and a vital mangrove system — the case that persuades the informed and the courts.
- **A livelihood argument:** it would ruin the fishers' nursery grounds and their catch — the case that unites the coastal communities.
- **A public argument:** they would bulldoze our largest protected area, in secret, for a foreign port — the case that moves the nation.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Jamaica the arguments that most often decide things are the **protected-area** one, because it is the legal shield, and the **secrecy** one, because it turns the public against the project. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the record and a claim made to a judge can be proven by the law; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the intrusion on protected land and the unlawful process framed against the law, with the documents that prove them.

The agencies respond to the legal risk of a quashed permit and to the weight of public and scientific opinion.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a secret deal to bulldoze the country's largest protected area, the last refuge of an endemic species, for a foreign port.

The public needs the argument simple and true: our protected area, our fish, our heritage, threatened in secret for someone's profit.

The scientists and conservation networks respond to the threat to endemic species, the mangroves, and the watershed — the irreplaceable natural values.

The community and the Maroons need to see their land, water, and rights are defensible, so they stay committed, as the Cockpit Country communities have stayed committed for years.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Jamaica, where public opinion moves the government, it may be the most important lever of all. Coverage exposes the secrecy, shifts opinion, and pressures the state. The Goat Islands campaign succeeded in large part because it turned a secret deal into a national controversy — a threat to the country's largest protected area that Jamaicans would not accept.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place, a documented wrong, and a natural and human stake. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a port planned in secret would bulldoze the country's largest protected area and the last refuge of an endemic species, ruining the fishers' grounds" is — the story that saved Goat Islands. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the secrecy, the protected status, the harm to the endemic life and the fishers — and offer a human and natural voice: a fisher, a scientist, the threatened iguana and mangroves. In Jamaica the story of a protected area and a people's heritage threatened in secret is one the nation has responded to before.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because a threat to a national protected area is a national story that moves the public and the government. Then the **international and conservation ring** — the international conservation press and networks — because global attention to an endemic species and a great protected area adds weight, as it did for Goat Islands. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national ring is decisive** in Jamaica, because national opinion moves the government, but the international conservation ring adds real pressure. The international dimension carries a particular weight in Jamaica's case because the natural values at stake are globally recognised: an island with an exceptional share of species found nowhere else, a critically endangered iguana that is a conservation cause in its own right, a great protected area noted by international

bird and conservation bodies. A campaign that frames its fight not only as a local or national matter but as the defence of world heritage can enlist that international standing, and the attention and reputational pressure it brings can move a government that weighs how it is seen abroad, as it did over the Goat Islands.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Jamaican fight can run through a long campaign or a longer boundary battle. Plan a sequence — the secret deal, the harm, the protected status, the coalition, the government's retreat — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; the investor and the agencies will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, well-evidenced campaign is what moves a government. Verified, specific, protected-area-and-secrecy-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped save the Goat Islands.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the agencies, the investors, the courts, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the protected status, the process, and the harm.

8A. Request for Information and the Deal (Access to Information)

To: the relevant agency (NEPA / the ministry / the Port Authority) **Subject:** Request for information on [project] in [protected area]

Under the access-to-information law, we, [community/organisation], request the **agreement, the permits, the environmental assessment, and all documents** relating to [project] in [protected area]. This project affects a protected area and the public interest, and the public has a right to know. Please provide the documents within the statutory period.

8B. Objection to the Project and the Process

To: the environmental regulator / the ministry **Subject:** Objection to [project] in [protected area]

We, [community/organisation], object to [project]. It **intrudes on [protected area]**, threatens [the mangroves / the endemic species / the watershed / the fishers' grounds], and was advanced **in secret / without proper assessment**, contrary to law and the public interest. We demand that it be **halted and its process opened**, and we reserve our right to challenge it before the courts.

8C. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the courts (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to [project / permit] in [protected area]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge [project / permit] as **unlawful**: it intrudes on a **protected area**, and the permit was granted **without proper assessment or process**. We seek its **quashing** and the halting of works, and attach the record demonstrating the protected status and the flaws.

8D. Letter to the Investor

To: the investor / developer **Subject:** The community's opposition to [project]

We write regarding [project] in [protected area]. The community and a broad coalition oppose it: it would destroy a protected area, threaten endemic species and our fishing grounds, and it was advanced in secret. We call on you to **abandon** the project, and we advise that the coalition will pursue every lawful lever — the protected-area law, the courts, transparency, and public opinion — against it, as the Goat Islands coalition did.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Environmental Organisation

To: an environmental organisation / public-interest lawyer **Subject:** [Project] — protected status, process, and the

challenge

We are opposing [project] in [protected area]. We attach the deal and permits (where obtained), the protected-area status, and our evidence of harm, and seek advice on **the protected-area and permit challenge, the transparency demand, and the public campaign**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8F. Appeal to the Environmental Movement / International Networks

To: the environmental organisations / international conservation networks **Subject:** Support for the defence of [protected area]

We write regarding [project], which threatens [protected area], its endemic species, and our communities. As the movement and the world stood with the campaign to save the Goat Islands, we ask for your **expertise, legal support, and international attention**. We attach our case and can host you at the site.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the protected area / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something the public should know, with a clear hook: [documents] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a port planned in secret would bulldoze the country's largest protected area and the last refuge of an endemic species"]. It echoes Goat Islands. I can share the file and connect you with a fisher and a scientist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/coalition] opposes [project]

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would **destroy [protected area]**, threaten its endemic life and our livelihoods, and was advanced in secret. As Jamaicans saved the Goat Islands, we will use the protected-area law, the courts, transparency, and public opinion to stop it. We call on the government to heed the public and the law, and we will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an objection, or a challenge is itself evidence, and exactly what the agencies, the courts, and the public will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the protected status, the process, and the harm; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the environmental organisations, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in Jamaica that record feeds the levers that matter most: the protected-area law and the courts, the demand for transparency, and the public opinion that moves the government.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Establish the protected status and the harm.** Find out whether the project touches a protected area or watershed and what it would destroy (Step 1, Step 2).
- 2. Demand the documents.** Use the access-to-information law to obtain the deal, the permit, and the assessment — and make secrecy the story if they are withheld (8A).
- 3. Reach the environmental organisations.** Connect with the Jamaica Environment Trust and its peers for expertise and legal support (8E, 8F).
- 4. Object on the record.** Put your objection and the protected-area intrusion on the record (8B).
- 5. Move the public.** Take the secrecy and the harm to the press and the public (Step 5, 8G).

6. Threaten the legal ground. With a lawyer, challenge a project that intrudes on protected land or rests on a flawed permit (8C).

7. Build the coalition. Unite the fishers, communities, scientists, and Maroons (Step 3).

Do only the first three and you will have established the protected status, demanded the documents, and drawn in the movement — the foundation of a Jamaican defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: establish the protected status, demand the documents, bring in the movement.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Jamaica's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. The **bauxite economy** gives mining a powerful pull, and the state has long treated it as central to the country's prosperity, tilting decisions toward mining even in sensitive places like the Cockpit Country. **Foreign investment and big projects** carry political weight, and deals — like the Goat Islands port — can be made in **secret**, presented to the public and even the protected-area managers as done. **Agencies can be under-resourced or deferential**, and an environmental assessment can be rushed toward a favourable result. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the agencies will protect the environment, or that a protected status is untouchable, will be disappointed — as the shrinking of the Cockpit Country boundary showed.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real levers remain.

Protected-area law is still a shield. Protected status is a real legal and political obstacle a project must overcome, as the Portland Bight status was.

The courts still hold agencies to the law. Environmental litigation has forced agencies to follow their own process, and the threat of it shapes decisions.

Secrecy is still a weakness. Exposing a hidden deal is both a legal and a political weapon, as it was at Goat Islands.

The movement still moves the public. Jamaica's environmental organisations and a free press can rouse a public that moves the government.

The Maroons and communities still hold their claims. The historic autonomy of the Maroons and the ties of communities to their land and water are a real and distinctive claim.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Jamaica is realistic but far from hopeless: the bauxite economy and foreign-investment pressure tilt the field, and some wins are partial, but the protected-area law, the courts, transparency, the movement, and public opinion give a determined coalition real levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: establish the **protected status** and the **harm**; expose the **secrecy** and the **flawed process**; build the **coalition**; use the **protected-area law and the courts**; and **move the public** — while understanding that the economic pull is strong and the win may be partial and in need of defending, as the Cockpit Country's is. Do not assume the system will protect the land on its own; Goat Islands was saved because a coalition made it impossible to ignore.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Jamaica has real concerns about how big deals and concessions are made, and the secrecy that can surround them, so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the public interest but by a deal made in secret to benefit an investor or the connected, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **deal made in secret**, hidden from the public and even the protected-area managers, as the Goat Islands deal was; an **assessment rushed** toward a favourable result; a **protected status quietly shrunk** to suit a mining interest, as the Cockpit Country boundary was drawn smaller than the science advised; **agencies deferring** to a powerful investor; and **benefits to the connected** while the community and the environment bear the harm. Trace the deal and the interests: who made it, in secret, who profits, whether the public interest and the protected land were sacrificed. In Jamaica, a project advanced in secrecy against a protected area is often not a mere policy choice but an arrangement that serves the connected.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the government and the agencies** can be captured by a powerful investor or the pull of the bauxite economy. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, which hold agencies to the law; the **environmental organisations** and their legal advocacy; the **free press**; the **scientists and conservation networks**; the **Maroons and the communities**; and the **public**, whose opinion moves the government. Capture thrives on secrecy and the public's inattention; your task is to break the secrecy, document the capture, and rouse the coalition and the public against it.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured deal cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the deal was made in secret, who benefits, what protected land and public interest were sacrificed — and take it to the forces that can act: the **courts**, to hold the agencies to the law; the **environmental organisations**, for expertise and litigation; the **free press and international networks**, to expose it; and the **public**, whose voice moves the government. Pair the exposure with the protected-area and legal challenge, so the impropriety and the pressure arrive together. In Jamaica, exposing how a deal was made in secret against a protected area, and rousing the public against it, is often the way to stop it — as the exposure of the secret Goat Islands deal helped save the protected area. There is a wider significance to winning such a fight that a community should hold onto: every secret deal dragged into the light, and every protected area successfully defended, strengthens the expectation that decisions over public land must be made openly and lawfully, and warns the next investor and the next official that a project advanced in secrecy against protected land can be exposed and beaten. The Goat Islands victory became exactly such a marker in Jamaica, and a community that fights and wins joins and extends that record, defending not only its own protected place but the principle that protects them all.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Jamaica turns on the protected status, the exposure of secrecy, and the mobilised public.

Early (Months 0-6): The Protected Status, the Coalition, and the Documents

Pin down the project and the deciding agency (Step 1); establish the **protected status** and document the **harm** and any **secrecy** (Step 2). Build the **coalition** with the environmental organisations, scientists, and communities (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **demand the documents** (8A); **object on the record** (8B); reach a **lawyer and the environmental organisations** early (8E, 8F); and begin to **move the public** (Step 5, 8G). This phase lays the foundation, and in Jamaica the protected status, the exposed secrecy, and the coalition established here are what win.

Middle (Months 3-24): Expose, Challenge, and Mobilise

Sustain the coalition and the communities (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Mount the **protected-area and permit challenge** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, exposing the secrecy and the harm from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — exposing the deal and challenging the process before the project hardens — because those chances do not return.

Later (Months 6-36+): The Retreat, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **project abandoned, the permit quashed, the protected area held** — and then stay vigilant, because, as with the Goat Islands port and the Cockpit Country boundary, a project can **move or return**, and a protected status can be **shrunk**. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped and a protected area saved, as at Goat Islands. Sometimes it is a partial protection, won and then defended year after year, as in the Cockpit Country. Both are victories worth the fight. And even a partial win compounds over time: a protected boundary won,

however contested, sets a line that must now be defended rather than conceded, a secret deal exposed makes the next one harder to keep hidden, and a record built in one fight arms the coalition that takes up the next. A campaign should value what it can win now, not only for its own protected place but for the way each exposed deal and each defended designation strengthens the wider movement that saved the Goat Islands.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-6	Establish protected status + harm Demand the documents Build the coalition Object Begin moving the public
MONTHS 3-24	Expose the secrecy Protected-area + permit challenge Mobilise the public Media
MONTHS 6-36+	Project abandoned / permit quashed / area held Guard against its return or shrinking

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Jamaica gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Protected-area law** gives communities a legal shield, as the Portland Bight status did for Goat Islands. A **strong environmental movement** — the Jamaica Environment Trust and its peers — brings the expertise and the legal advocacy to document, campaign, and litigate. The **demand for transparency** turns a secret deal into a scandal. The **Maroons and communities** hold historic and living claims to their land and water. And **public opinion**, in an open democracy, moves the government. These are the tools that let a coalition save the country's largest protected area from a foreign-backed port. They are, notably, tools that depend on breadth, expertise, and openness rather than on wealth or connections, which is why a coalition of organisations, scientists, and ordinary Jamaicans could prevail over a foreign state company and a government set on the deal — and why, used with the same care, they remain available to communities across the island wherever protected land is threatened.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. Goat Islands was saved, but the **port ambition moved on**. Cockpit Country's win was **partial and contested**, its boundary drawn smaller than the science advised, against the pull of the **bauxite economy**. No guide should pretend these away; in Jamaica, the art is to use the strong tools well, to expose the secrecy, to build the broad coalition, and to keep defending a win that powerful interests will try to erode.

So the realistic promise is this: **establish the protected status and the harm; expose the secrecy and the flawed process; build the coalition; use the protected-area law and the courts; and move the public — running all of it together**. Do that, and where protected land is threatened and the process is flawed or secret, you can stop a project and save a protected area, as the Goat Islands coalition did; where the economic pull is strong, you can still win partial protection, delay, and a record, and keep fighting, as the Cockpit Country defenders do. Do it as the Goat Islands campaign did — Jamaicans who exposed a secret deal, documented the harm, built a broad coalition, and saved their largest protected area.

A last word on the coalition and the public. Jamaica's lesson is that a broad, expert coalition, rooted in communities and armed with the protected-area law, holds more power than the state and a foreign investor expect — that a secret deal to bulldoze the country's largest protected area can be exposed and defeated by a roused public — but that the win must be defended, because the economic pull and the foreign-investment pressure do not vanish. The powerful count on your resignation, your division, and the secrecy that keeps you in the dark. Their advantage is the bauxite economy, the foreign money, and the deal made behind closed doors. Yours is the protected-area law, the courts, a strong environmental movement, the Maroons' and communities' claims, a free press, and the proven fact that the Goat Islands were saved. Play to that. Keep the record and the proof of the protected status and the secrecy, keep the coalition broad and the public engaged, wield the law and the courts, and treat every exposed deal, every filing, every roused public, and every protected acre held as a stone in a wall that even the bauxite pressure cannot easily climb.

The tools are here, and Jamaica itself proved them: a coalition of organisations, scientists, fishers, and citizens that exposed a secret deal, documented the harm to a great protected area and an endemic species, and made the government abandon a foreign-backed port on the Goat Islands. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the breadth of the coalition, the protected-area law, the exposure of secrecy, and the roused public — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the protected status and the documents and the coalition, and build from there. Communities before you have saved a protected area and defended their heritage — a port stopped, a secret deal exposed, a protected area held. They did it with breadth, persistence, and the full use of the levers an open democracy provides, against a foreign investor and a government that wanted the project built, and at times against long odds — which is exactly why your own coalition's effort, added to theirs, is neither hopeless nor unimportant. What the Goat Islands coalition won can be won again. So can yours. A coalition that dragged a secret deal into the light, marshalled the science on what would be lost, and refused to let the nation's largest protected area be bulldozed for a port has shown

what an open democracy's tools can do in determined hands; the protected-area law, the courts, the demand for transparency, the coalition, and the public are the method, and the proof that even a foreign-backed megaproject can be stopped is now yours to take up and use.